

Chapter 16 - Dream

Chu Qingqiu stared steadily at those bloodstains. Her left hand slowly rose, and pieces of heavenly light transformed into feather shapes, gathering from beyond the sky and converging into her heart. From a distance, it looked like brilliant stars falling at dusk, connecting heaven and earth as one.

When the last piece of orange-yellow faded and the flying feathers disappeared, only then did Chu Qingqiu straighten her waist. Her complexion was pale, as if she had suddenly become much more frail.

"Qiu Yi." She spoke, and as soon as her voice fell, the tall woman appeared before her with a "pop," breaking through the void.

"Master." Qiu Yi immediately saw the blood on Chu Qingqiu's hands and at the corner of her mouth, becoming nervous at once. "This..."

"It's nothing." Chu Qingqiu shook her head. "The North Courtyard disciples are going to Tongchuan¹. Which places will they pass through?"

Chu Qingqiu had always been the strongest in Qiu Yi's eyes, and also the person she most respected. Seeing Chu Qingqiu in this state now, her heart twisted into a knot, but she didn't dare to ask questions. She could only grit her teeth and answer: "I heard people say they'll rest one night in Furong Town² and enter Tongchuan early the next morning."

Hearing this, Chu Qingqiu nodded: "Good. You may go."

"Master, are you going to Furong Town? Please take Qiu Yi with you. I'm not at ease with you going alone." Qiu Yi suddenly lowered her head and boldly called out.

"With my cultivation level, what is there for you to worry about?" Chu Qingqiu stepped forward, and the bloodstains on her body disappeared without a trace. "Besides, Cloud Ascension Mountain Gate isn't safe either. Keeping you here means you can send messages to me if anything happens."

"But..." Qiu Yi wanted to say more, but suddenly felt warmth from a palm on top of her head, blocking all her remaining words.

"Be obedient." Chu Qingqiu patted her head, then brushed past her, leaving behind a faint fragrance.

Chu Qingqiu was rarely this gentle. She was always cold without warmth, never even speaking soft words. But somehow, starting from some unknown day, she seemed to have changed somewhat, yet also seemed to have changed nothing at all.

Qiu Yi was somewhat dazed. She longingly touched the top of her head, and when she turned around again, only thin darkness remained on the cliff, along with leaves blown by the wind all over the sky.

Meanwhile, in distant Furong Town, a farce was just beginning.

The little white dog seemed to sense danger and kept struggling violently, its cries miserable and desperate. But the more pitifully it called, the more excited the surrounding crowd became, continuously clapping and cheering.

The giant lion in the cage also smelled the scent of food. Its mountain-like body suddenly rose from the ground, roaring as it opened its bloody maw.

Just as the hand holding the little dog was about to let go, the Dongyue man who had been cheerful suddenly became terrified, then screamed with bloodshot eyes. The surrounding crowd also screamed in alarm, crowding together and scattering in all directions.

The giant lion that had just been trapped in the cramped cage had somehow broken open the cage door. Without the suppression of the black iron cage, its body instantly swelled, then it roared toward the sky. Immediately, fierce winds arose, making it impossible for people to open their eyes.

"Quick! Form an array!" The Dongyue man sternly called to his companions, but just as he turned around, he was splattered with blood and flesh. After wiping it away with his hand, he discovered in terror that his companion who had been standing behind him was now collapsed in a pool of blood. He quickly turned to summon his weapon, but the giant lion, which had been tortured and covered in wounds, was far more frenzied than usual. It ignored the long blade in his hand and, like Mount Tai pressing down³, desperately charged toward him.

This wasn't all. As the giant lion regained its freedom, the restrictions on all the other black iron cages also completely disappeared. Dozens of wounded spirit beasts broke out of their cages together, roaring madly in unison, like the mournful cries of ten thousand beasts.

"How can this be!" The Dongyue man was almost scared out of his wits by these maddened spirit beasts. No longer able to use any of his skills, his legs went weak and he knelt on the ground. Muddy urine soaked through his pants. The giant lion opened and closed its mouth, and he disappeared from the spot, leaving only a ground full of stench.

Li Chao'an had never seen such a scene. She immediately covered her mouth and cried out, her delicate body going soft and nearly fainting. It was Shao Bing⁴ beside her who supported her. The three of them were so frightened they forgot even their immortal techniques, crying and screaming as they ran with the crowd. But they accidentally fell to the ground and were dragged away by a spirit fox that leaped over them, gripping her pants leg and dragging her to who knows where.

Liu Wenzhu was also extremely terrified, tears continuously dripping from her eyes like rain falling from eaves, pattering non-stop.

"Yiyi, Yiyi, wake up quickly!" She shook Ning Fuyi, but Ning Fuyi seemed to have lost her soul, motionless. Only black mist continued to pour from her palms. Later, Liu Wenzhu simply tried to carry her up, but despite all her strength, she couldn't move Ning Fuyi even a fraction.

"Yiyi..." Liu Wenzhu was already timid by nature, and now she was completely panicked. Moreover, the herd of beasts was already charging in their direction, trampling all debris into mud along the way. The earth shook violently - it was terrifying.

Just as the beast herd was about to trample over them, Liu Wenzhu suddenly closed her eyes and positioned her entire body in front of Ning Fuyi, using her delicate, willow-like frame to firmly protect the girl's body in her arms.

"Yiyi..." She sobbed in her ear.

Like wind blowing into chaotic black mist, a bright light suddenly appeared in Ning Fuyi's groggy mind, dispelling the thick hatred. The world before her eyes instantly became clear. In that moment, two streams of black smoke, so powerful they almost had physical form, surged up from the earth's crust like thick city walls, separating the spirit beasts on both sides.

The spirit beasts roared past, and the sand and dust they kicked up drifted in the air, falling on top of the two people.

Ning Fuyi's eyes, which had returned to clarity, still held a trace of confusion. Her friend's warm tears soaked her shoulder, and it seemed someone was tugging at her clothing, pulling her askew.

So Ning Fuyi looked down to see a dirty little white dog sitting with a plop, wagging its tail at her.

"Ping'an, you're really ugly," Ning Fuyi chuckled softly.

Then her knees went weak, and she lost consciousness.

Perhaps stimulated by that black mist, some memories that didn't seem to belong to her appeared in Ning Fuyi's dreams. But every scene in the dream was very clear - so clear she could almost recall those sensations.

In the dream, she was still the infamous Heaven-Slaughtering Demon God⁵, cursing and swearing as she carried a woman, desperately running through chaos, as if fleeing from something deadly.

She seemed to hate that woman very much, cursing and swearing every moment they were together, except when the woman was asleep.

Then when the woman woke up, she would carry her and run again, continuing to curse and swear.

In the dream, such days seemed to last for a very long time. Later, she seemed to stop cursing, perhaps because she was tired of it, or perhaps because she didn't want to curse anymore. Only silence remained between them.

But that silence carried very strong sadness, as if they wanted to be close but shouldn't be.

But there wasn't only silence between them. Occasionally, some fragments would appear in the dream - fragments that made Ning Fuyi blush and her heart race. But when she tried to look more closely at those fragments, the dream would abruptly end.

Ning Fuyi also awakened from the dream, waking with tears in her eyes that burned her eyelids painfully.

However, this tremendous sadness didn't linger long. The moment Ning Fuyi opened her eyes, she began to rapidly forget this dream, along with those fragments, as if someone had extracted them from her memory, leaving not a trace.

So half an incense stick's time later⁶, she stretched lazily and sat up in bed.

"Yiyi!" A soft, sweet voice rang out. Liu Wenzhu came floating in from outside like the wind, holding a cotton ball in her arms. When the cotton ball saw Ning Fuyi, it excitedly barked once and jumped onto Ning Fuyi's lap, wagging its head and tail.

The little white dog's soft tongue licked across the back of her hand - the same warm sensation as in her previous life. Ning Fuyi's heart bloomed like a flower, becoming bright and sunny.

Perhaps it was fate's design - in her previous life, Ping'an had been found in the mountains by Rong Jin, but in this life, she had encountered it early.

"Ping'an." She called out in a tender voice, and the cotton ball stretched out its little short legs and bounced into her arms.

Ping'an had already been washed clean by Liu Wenzhu. Except for its tail, it was pure white all over. The wounds on its body had also been bandaged, and its round eyes looked at her wetly - it was extremely adorable.

"Yiyi, yesterday you..." Seeing her smiling face, Liu Wenzhu finally felt relieved and began to inquire.

Ning Fuyi's smile froze for a moment, then she said softly: "I can't explain this matter to you yet. In the future..."

Liu Wenzhu's beautiful eyes lowered, and two shallow dimples appeared at the corners of her lips: "Forget it. I have no intention of forcing you to tell me. I just feel that we are each other's best friends in this life, and you've always discussed everything with me before."

"I only hope you know what you're doing and won't hurt yourself. Rest assured, no one else saw what happened yesterday, and I won't say anything about it." Liu Wenzhu took out a flatbread from her sleeve and stuffed it into Ning Fuyi's hands. "Eat quickly. The Flying Eagle Boat⁷ will depart in a quarter hour."

"I'm sorry." Ning Fuyi took the still-warm flatbread and quickly said.

Liu Wenzhu was a sensitive person by nature, but she was very perceptive in her dealings with people, often making Ning Fuyi feel ashamed of herself.

"Saying sorry is appropriate - you scared me to death yesterday." Liu Wenzhu winked at her, then got up lightly. "But do you know where Li Chao'an was found?"

"Where?" Ning Fuyi took a bite of the flatbread and widened her eyes.

"A fox den!" Liu Wenzhu couldn't help covering her mouth and giggling. "She was dragged all the way to Tongchuan by that spirit fox. She even broke her leg along the way. When Senior Brother Xue Chi found her in the fox den, she had already fainted from fright for a whole night."

"Poor Senior Brother Xue Chi from the East Courtyard - he just came to Tongchuan and had to take her back for treatment. What a wasted trip." Liu Wenzhu's eyes curved into crescents.

"Serves her right." Ning Fuyi was also very happy. She lowered her head and kissed Ping'an's fluffy forehead twice, making Ping'an whimper and cover its face with its two little paws.

Yesterday's scene was like a great dream. Now that she was awake, there was nothing left in her body again. Ning Fuyi was somewhat disappointed, but more than that, she was relieved, because if she hadn't awakened in that situation, Liu Wenzhu and Ping'an would surely have been in danger.

It seemed she needed to be more careful about the occasions in the future. Even if she was going to turn demonic, she couldn't let herself lose her reason.

When they boarded the Flying Eagle Boat, everyone had already assembled. Everyone only knew they had encountered escaped spirit beasts, and some people came to ask after them. Liu Wenzhu smiled and responded to each one.

There was also Rong Jin, who had worried himself into dark circles under his eyes. He kept pulling at Ning Fuyi and chattering non-stop along the way until Ning Fuyi became drowsy, and only then did he stop talking and go take the helm, shaking his head.

Elder Yuanming, however, didn't say a single word of reprimand. He only inquired with concern in a low voice, then began praising them for being fearless in the face of danger at such a young age, saying they were good candidates for traveling the world and helping others heroically in the future.

Liu Wenzhu and Ning Fuyi exchanged glances and giggled with their hands over their mouths.

The sunlight gradually became scorching. The rolling hills beneath their feet were replaced by a huge dark shadow, and they knew Tongchuan had arrived.

"So this is what Tongchuan looks like - it appears dark and gloomy, quite eerie and terrifying." Liu Wenzhu looked at the increasingly clear continuous tree shadows and shivered against Ning Fuyi.

"Look, what are those eye-like things?"

"Ghost Eyes⁸." Ning Fuyi answered.

Liu Wenzhu covered her mouth and cried out in alarm, unable to help leaning closer: "Ghost Eyes?"

"Don't be afraid." Ning Fuyi patted her shoulder. "It's just a name. Actually, it's a deep valley among the mountains. Legend says it's full of poisonous smoke and miasma, harboring ancient fierce beasts. From ancient times to now, everyone who has gone down has never returned, so it's called the Ghost Eyes."

"So terrifying? Even Sect Master Mei couldn't manage it?" A female disciple with her hair in a high bun came over to ask.

"Of course not. Don't mention Sect Master Mei - I think even if Emperor Tianrui⁹ from Penglai Realm¹⁰ went down, he'd lose a layer of skin. However, there is someone in this world who has gone down and come back completely unharmed. Can you guess who?" A bald male disciple interjected.

"Who?" The female disciple widened her eyes.

"Naturally, it's Divine Venerable Chu Ling¹¹! Dummy." The male disciple said loudly. "The ever-changing magical artifact jade flute White Bone¹² that Divine Venerable Chu Ling holds was fished up from this Ghost Eye."

Ning Fuyi, who was listening nearby, raised an eyebrow and looked down.

It would have been better if she hadn't looked. With this one glance, she caused another great disturbance.

The Flying Eagle Boat beneath their feet, which had been stable, suddenly seemed to crash into something and began shaking violently. Everyone on the boat couldn't sit steady and squatted down screaming. Ning Fuyi was knocked by someone and nearly fell on the spot, but fortunately Liu Wenzhu was strong and pulled her back by the neck.

"You can't use sword flight yet - hold on tight!" Liu Wenzhu shouted. The Flying Eagle Boat was now shaking even more violently, as if it was about to split in two at any moment. Disciples with higher cultivation summoned their swords and flew on them in mid-air, while disciples who hadn't learned sword flight yet covered their heads and screamed heart-rendingly.

"Don't move around!" Elder Yuanming was also panicked now. He condensed his immortal power to check the Flying Eagle Boat but found no faults, and the surroundings were calm with nothing unusual.

Ning Fuyi was hit in the waist by someone again. She cursed angrily in her heart and quickly grabbed the handrail. If she had known this trip would encounter so many troubles, she would have learned sword flight first!

As her thoughts raced, the space beneath her feet suddenly became empty. The good Flying Eagle Boat suddenly broke in half from the middle, completely losing its immortal power and spinning as it fell toward the mountain forest. Disciples who couldn't use sword flight screamed as they fell like dumplings along with the Flying Eagle Boat.

Liu Wenzhu stood on her slender sword hilt, holding Ning Fuyi with one hand and grabbing Ping'an's fur with the other, so nervous her pretty face turned red.

"Everyone, don't panic!" Elder Yuanming's loud shout came from the distance, and then a net woven from vines appeared in mid-air, firmly catching the falling disciples.

Seeing that the usually unreliable Elder Yuanming had finally come through once, Ning Fuyi had just breathed a sigh of relief when that strange impact sensation struck again. With no one beside her, it violently knocked her out of Liu Wenzhu's hands.

She fell straight past that large net, heading directly toward the dark Ghost Eye.

Author's Note: Ning Fuyi: Me, I shouldn't have left the house today!

Footnotes:

- ¹ Tongchuan (铜川) - A dangerous region at the border of the Eastern Wasteland
- ² Furong Town (芙蓉镇) - A frontier town near Tongchuan
- ³ Mount Tai pressing down (泰山压顶) - Chinese idiom meaning overwhelming pressure
- ⁴ Shao Bing (邵冰) - One of Li Chao'an's followers
- ⁵ Heaven-Slaughtering Demon God (诛天神魔) - Ning Fuyi's title from her previous life as a demon lord
- ⁶ Half an incense stick's time - Traditional Chinese time measurement, roughly 15-30 minutes
- ⁷ Flying Eagle Boat (飞鹰舟) - A magical flying vessel shaped like an eagle
- ⁸ Ghost Eyes (鬼眼) - A dangerous valley/chasm in Tongchuan
- ⁹ Emperor Tianrui (天瑞帝君) - A powerful ruler from Penglai Realm
- ¹⁰ Penglai Realm (蓬莱境) - A mystical realm, traditionally the home of immortals
- ¹¹ Divine Venerable Chu Ling (褚凌神尊) - Chu Qingqiu's formal title
- ¹² White Bone (白骨) - Chu Qingqiu's shapeshifting magical weapon